

Media only as the Magi represented it; and the mirror they held was indifferently polished. It will be an advantage if at this point we stop to ask what were the main characteristics of Parsism as it would be understood by Jews living in Babylonia and Media during the last four centuries before Christ. It had lost the very features which bring the Gathas nearest to the spirit of Israel's prophets. Magian dualism and ritualism were firmly established. The Amshaspands, always an esoteric conception, had not begun to take their place beside the Yazatas of popular worship.¹ The Magi had popularised the aristocratic divinity Ahura Mazdah, and set by his side the foreign Anahita and the Aryan but now syncretised Mithra. A host of angels and an antithetic host of demons occupied a prominent place in the creed. Religious duties included the slaying of (theoretically) noxious animals, the performance of tedious ceremonial such as we find in large measure in the Vendidad, and the pronouncing of sacred formulæ as the most powerful of spells. With the ascendancy of the Magi came the commendation of next-of-kin marriages, with which the religion was necessarily credited, although these alien priests failed in their long struggle to get them established as orthodox. And the idea of immortality must have declined very much from its strongly ethical character. So far as the Magi took it up at all, it was only as a part of their mechanically balanced reconstruction: death must disappear in the new world just as mountains and shadows and dialects and other unsymmetrical things. As for Zarathushtra, the Magi claimed him as one of them-

¹ Except in name: see p. 100 f.